

# Heart Attack: recognize and act

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Some heart attacks start slowly, with mild pain or discomfort, while others are sudden and intense. Symptoms can vary widely, and many people do not experience classic crushing chest pain. When in doubt, call emergency help right away and follow dispatcher guidance.

## CALL EMERGENCY SERVICES NOW

### A heart attack is a medical emergency — call immediately

If you or someone else might be having a heart attack, call your local emergency number (examples: 911, 112, or 999; verify locally) right away. Do not wait to see if symptoms go away. Put the phone on speaker if you can and follow dispatcher or local emergency guidance.

## Recognize the signs of a heart attack

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1. **1 Chest discomfort.** Most heart attacks involve discomfort in the center of the chest that lasts more than a few minutes, or that goes away and comes back. It can feel like uncomfortable pressure, squeezing, fullness, or pain.
2. **2 Discomfort in other upper-body areas.** Symptoms can include pain or discomfort in one or both arms, the back, neck, jaw, or stomach.
3. **3 Shortness of breath.** This can happen with or without chest discomfort, sometimes as the only symptom.
4. **4 Other signs.** These may include breaking out in a cold sweat, feeling lightheaded or dizzy, or experiencing unexplained nausea or vomiting.

## SYMPTOMS CAN BE DIFFERENT FOR WOMEN

Like men, women's most common heart attack symptom is chest pain or discomfort. However, women are somewhat more likely than men to experience other common symptoms, particularly shortness of breath, nausea, vomiting, and back or jaw pain, without any chest pressure or pain. Do not ignore these subtler signs.

## What to do while you wait for medical help

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### KEEP THEM CALM AND COMFORTABLE

- **Sit down, rest, and stay calm.** Do not allow the person to walk, climb stairs, or exert themselves, as physical effort increases the strain on the heart.
- **Ask about aspirin only after calling.** Do not delay the emergency call to find aspirin. Give aspirin only if the dispatcher, a clinician, or local protocol tells you to and the person is alert enough to chew/swallow and has no aspirin allergy, aspirin intolerance, bleeding disorder or serious recent bleeding, blood-thinner concern, or other known reason to avoid it.
- **Loosen tight clothing.** Unbutton collars, loosen belts, and make sure their airway is completely clear.
- **Stay with them.** Reassure them continuously. Keep them sitting comfortably to help them breathe more easily.
- **Be ready to start CPR.** If the person becomes unresponsive and is not breathing normally, start Hands-Only CPR immediately. Put the phone on speaker and follow dispatcher instructions.

### WHAT NOT TO DO

- **Do not drive yourself or the patient to the hospital if emergency medical services are available.** Driving can be dangerous if symptoms worsen, and emergency responders can assess and guide care on the way.
- **Do not ignore symptoms or wait to see if they pass.** Many people delay seeking help because symptoms seem mild, unusual, or like indigestion or muscle strain.
- **Do not try “cough CPR.”** Coughing repeatedly and vigorously is an unsafe internet myth for bystanders and should not be used instead of calling emergency help.
- **Do not give food or drink.** Avoid food, alcohol, or unnecessary drinks while waiting for emergency help, especially if the person is nauseated, short of breath, confused, drowsy, or may need urgent treatment.

## Lower your risk

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- Monitor and control high blood pressure, high cholesterol, and diabetes under a clinician's care.
- Avoid smoking and limit alcohol consumption to low-risk levels.
- Maintain a healthy weight, eat a heart-healthy diet, and stay physically active.
- Understand your family medical history and discuss your cardiovascular risk factors with a doctor.

## Sources

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- American Heart Association (AHA) — Heart Attack Symptoms and Warning Signs.
- U.S. CDC — Heart Attack Symptoms and Risk Factors.
- National Heart, Lung, and Blood Institute (NHLBI) — Heart Attack.
- NHS — Heart attack symptoms and what to do.

- British Heart Foundation (BHF) — Heart Attack Symptoms and Action Guide.

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This guide is general information, not medical advice. In an emergency, always call your local emergency number without delay. Reuse and reprint freely.